Department of Political Science
Bunche Hall, 315 Portola Plaza
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1600

February 5, 2026

To whom it may concern:

I have had the pleasure of advising Joshua Goetz' dissertation, as well supervising Joshua as my teaching assistant for the Spring 2024 undergraduate political science course entitled "Mixed Methods Research" (PS 169). The course trains students to understand, implement, and combine quantitative, qualitative, and experimental methodologies, and for many students, serves as a primer to causal inference and coding, using the statistical programming language R.

Joshua was an excellent teaching assistant. Not only was he always available to help students work through R tutorials and refine their research projects --- two tasks which took much of his time both within and outside of regular office hours --- but he also proposed innovative and productive ideas for running sections. For instance, for a week on ethnography, Joshua came up with an applied discussion section exercise whereby he brought in snacks for the students, divided them into researchers and research participants, and directed the researchers to derive hypotheses about the cultural significance of food in social rituals, and test these hypotheses based on the participants' behavior. The participants then had to backwards-induce what the hypotheses might be, based on the results.

In addition to going above and beyond to help students --- many of them political scientists with no previous experience with long-term research projects, coding, or hypothesis-testing --- Joshua was also punctual and fair with grading assignments and participation.

As Joshua's dissertation advisor, I also oversee many of his own research projects. In doing so, I can attest to his knack for computational social science and causal inference, and his ability to apply these techniques to substantively interesting and important topics, such as differentiating different forms of discrimination. Josh is incredibly creative in his approach to political science. He sees the "real world" as a laboratory of sorts; an opportunity to study, measure, and (positively) shape the real-world behaviors of people from traditionally conflictual social groups.

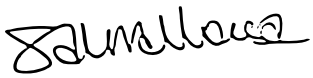
Josh can take seminal theories in economics, political science, and psychology --- such as Bayesian updating, statistical vs. taste-based discrimination, and framing effects --- and test nuanced dimensions of these ideas via field experiments. His experimental designs bring fresh energy and modern relevance to longstanding theories: from differentiating between antisemitism and anti-Zionism using dating apps, to measuring Islamophobia using nanny profiles. I have made a career out of designing field experiments aimed at improving intergroup relations with real-world outcomes, and see a great deal of potential in Josh's style of thinking and dedication to pulling off complex projects.

I wholeheartedly support Josh's nomination for UCLA's Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. His dedication to students, creative implementation of best practices in teaching, and the consistently excellent evaluations he receives from both his student and his supervisors all make him a deserving candidate for this award.

Please do not hesitate to reach out with additional questions.

Department of Political Science
Bunche Hall, 315 Portola Plaza
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1600

Best,



Salma Mousa

Assistant Professor

Department of Political Science

To Whom It May Concern,

I am writing to apply for UCLA's Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. My teaching is grounded in evidence-based, student-centered practices that aim to reduce barriers to learning, actively engage students, and support the success of students with diverse backgrounds and levels of preparation. Across a wide range of instructional contexts, I have worked intentionally to design discussion sections that are inclusive, rigorous, and responsive to student needs.

My teaching experience spans multiple disciplines and instructional environments, including Game Theory, African Political Economy, Mixed Methods Research, and World Politics in the Political Science department at UCLA; a graduate-level modeling and simulation course in Ohio State University's Chemical Engineering department; English instruction at the K-12 level in Morocco; and serving as the sole instructor for UCLA Political Science's Math Camp in Summer 2025. These experiences have required me to adapt my pedagogy to students with widely varying levels of prior knowledge, confidence, and learning goals. As a result, I have become particularly attentive to identifying learning barriers and adjusting my teaching strategies accordingly.

A recurring barrier I have observed is student anxiety—especially in quantitative or theory-heavy courses—which can suppress participation and inhibit learning. In response, I consistently incorporate active-learning strategies such as low-stakes problem-solving, small-group discussion, and structured participation prompts. For example, in Game Theory sections, I replace purely lecture-based explanations with collaborative exercises in which students work through strategic scenarios together before discussing them as a class. In World Politics, I interspersed review lectures with gamified competitions between students to teach the logic of bargaining in war. This approach lowers the cost of being wrong, encourages peer learning, and helps students internalize abstract concepts. Student feedback frequently notes that these activities made challenging material feel more accessible and engaging.

I also place strong emphasis on clarity and transparency in assessment. In African Political Economy, students expressed uncertainty about expectations for a written assignment. After identifying this as a barrier to student success, I collaborated with another TA to develop a detailed grading rubric. Students reported that these materials significantly reduced confusion and helped them feel more confident in their work.

In general, my teaching is iterative and responsive. During every section meeting, I solicit feedback through brief surveys embedded in attendance forms and use this feedback to make real-time adjustments to my sections. For instance, when students in World Politics indicated that discussion was more beneficial than example exercises in the weeks following the midterm, I rebalanced class time accordingly. Survey responses consistently reflect appreciation for this responsiveness and for the supportive classroom climate I strive to create. When numerous students indicate confusion over a specific topic, I set aside time for an extra review on that topic during the next class.

Beyond my own sections, I am committed to improving teaching within my department. I regularly contribute my materials—slides, activities, problem sets, and discussion prompts—to a shared Google Drive that other TAs are encouraged to adapt and use. I have also met informally with junior TAs to discuss best practices, classroom management, and ways to implement active-learning strategies effectively.

I also seek out opportunities to grow as an instructor. Whether through formal workshops, conversations with faculty and graduate students, or self-directed reflection on what works and what does not, I continuously refine my teaching practice. The Political Science Department's decision to select me as the sole instructor for Math Camp—a role focused on supporting students with highly varied mathematical backgrounds—reflects both my commitment to inclusive teaching and my effectiveness in practice.

Overall, my goal as a TA is not only to help students master course material, but to make learning feel approachable, collaborative, and worthwhile. I strive to create classroom environments in which students feel supported, challenged, and empowered to succeed. The feedback I consistently receive from students, including written SET reviews, demonstrates that I am effective in this regard. I would be honored to be considered for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Joshua Goetz

My approach to teaching is grounded in the belief that students learn most effectively when they feel supported, respected, intellectually challenged, and treated as active participants in the learning process. Across a range of courses in areas including Political Science, Engineering, English, Mathematics, and more, I strive to create a learning environment that is accessible, rigorous, supportive, and flexible.

A core principle of my teaching is preparation. I intentionally overprepare for discussion sections, developing multiple pathways through the material so that instruction can adapt to students' needs in real time. For a typical section meeting, this means arriving with a review of core concepts, an interactive activity, a set of discussion questions, and applied examples or case studies. This approach allows me to pivot when students indicate that a particular topic requires additional attention or when engagement with an activity is lower than expected. Rather than viewing unused material as wasted effort, I see this preparation as essential to effective teaching: it deepens my own mastery of the content, enables me to answer questions more confidently, and provides students with additional resources, as I always share my full slidedeck with students after class for review purposes.

Because no single approach works for every group of students, I regularly solicit feedback through weekly attendance forms and use it to adjust my instruction to the needs of each section.

These methods reflect a broader willingness to devote time and energy to teaching. While some view teaching as secondary to research, I am equally motivated by both. I spend time outside of class developing groupwork problems, taking notes on readings, and attending lectures even when not required. I often stay for extra time when my office hours are crowded or create additional sessions if there is sufficient demand. I regularly emphasize that students should feel free to ask questions in class or in office hours, and I respond to student emails in far more detail than could be reasonably expected of a TA. I genuinely enjoy helping students learn, and that enjoyment shapes the time and care I bring to teaching.

I also believe that learning is fundamentally social, and I make a deliberate effort to foster collaboration and community within my sections. On the first day of every quarter, I set aside time for students to introduce themselves to their neighbors and exchange contact information, forming the beginnings of peer support networks. Encouraging collaboration helps normalize uncertainty and reduces students' reluctance to ask questions, since many students feel more comfortable directing questions to a peer than to an instructor.

Equity and inclusion are central considerations in how I design and implement my teaching practices. I am especially attentive to the ways structural and economic factors can shape students' ability to engage fully with a course. Whenever possible and consistent with course policies, I build in flexibility around attendance, office hours, and communication, and I make myself available to students through multiple modalities. I am willing to meet outside of scheduled office hours and to accommodate students with work obligations, long commutes, or

other responsibilities. My goal is not to lower standards, but to minimize unnecessary barriers so that all students have a fair opportunity to succeed.

While I aim to create an inclusive and supportive learning environment, I also maintain high academic standards. I believe that clarity, fairness, and consistency are essential to rigor. Students benefit when expectations are transparent and when grades meaningfully reflect their understanding and effort. I emphasize academic integrity and take it seriously, not as a punitive measure, but as a cornerstone of equitable evaluation. Holding students to clear standards ensures that those who invest time and effort in mastering the material are appropriately recognized, which is particularly important for students seeking to distinguish themselves academically.

Indeed, I see rigor and inclusion as complementary, rather than competing aspects of teaching. Grade inflation erases a straightforward mechanism through which disadvantaged students can signal their competency, forcing employers to look elsewhere. Under such a system, students can only distinguish themselves through extracurriculars such as internships (which are often unpaid in political science), volunteering abroad, or club activities, all of which have significant barriers for students who are low-income, working part-time jobs, or lack connections. Under the assumption that it is more difficult for disadvantaged students to distinguish themselves outside the classroom than within it, I conclude that rigorous and discriminating grading schemes are imperative for minimizing barriers and advancing equity and inclusion.

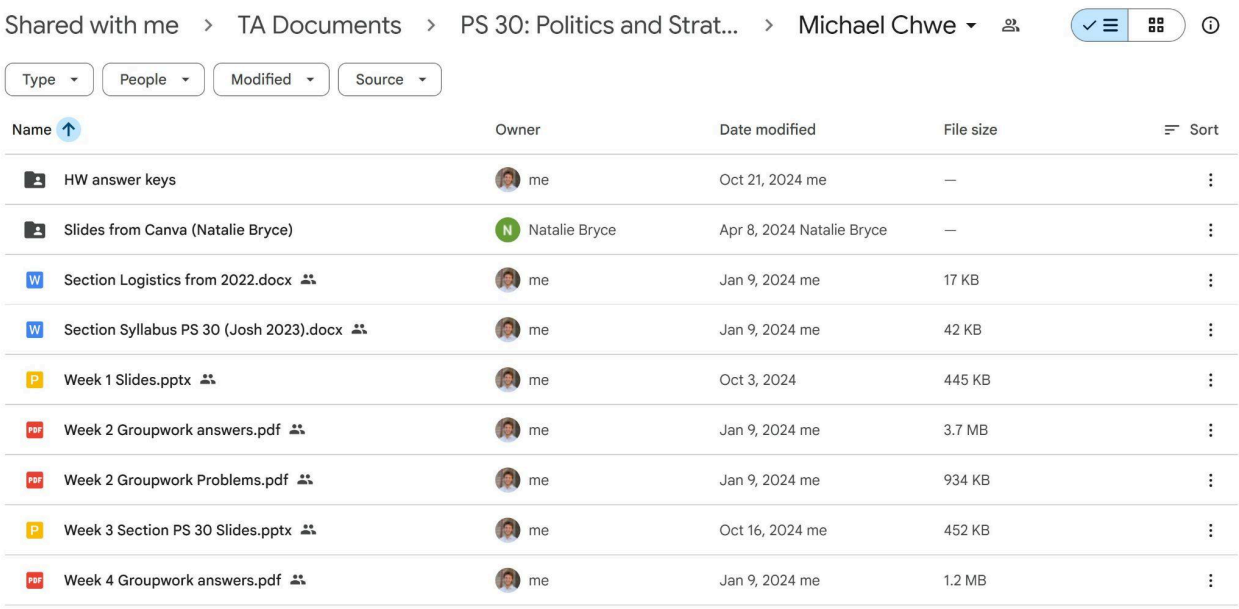
Underlying all of these practices is a belief in treating students with respect and approaching them as capable partners in the learning process. I treat students as equals rather than subordinates; I learn students' names early, and encourage questions both in and outside of class. My goal is that students feel comfortable admitting confusion and seeking clarification without fear of judgment. When students feel respected and supported, I believe they are more willing to ask questions, take intellectual risks, and attend office hours.

Finally, I understand that students come to the classroom with diverse interests and aspirations. While not every student will pursue further study in political science, each of them deserves the opportunity to learn the material, develop analytical skills, and leave the course with a deeper understanding of the world. For students who express deeper interest, I aim to provide additional challenges and content to push them to learn more and excel further.

In sum, my teaching philosophy revolves around thoughtful preparation, responsiveness to student needs, inclusive and equitable course design, and a commitment to rigorous evaluation. I continually reflect on and refine my teaching practices, viewing teaching as a craft that improves through experience, feedback, and intentional growth. Through this approach, I aim to create learning environments in which students feel supported, challenged, and empowered to succeed.

Section	What concepts in class are you most confused about?	Suggestions to improve section?
1C (6:00)		doing fantastic
1C (6:00)	na	everything is good so far!
1C (6:00)	Homework 7	G
1A (4:00)		Go over the hw problems
1A (4:00)	Hw 6	Go over x problems
1C (6:00)	The previous lesson	Going over homework
1A (4:00)	-	how to approach m and p problems
1A (4:00)	X problems 😓	I like how you're incorporating feedback and stuff
1B (5:00)		I like it when we review HW!
1A (4:00)	nothing in particular right now	I think everything's good right now!
1A (4:00)	Na	It's great
1B (5:00)	Im sort of confused on the new topics so borda and cordorecet,	Its been very helpful!
1A (4:00)	about how one setting the agenda affects others in the voting scenarios	its great thank you!
1C (6:00)	Some homework	Just going over the material
1A (4:00)	N/A	N/A
1A (4:00)	finding the condorcet winner when there's a variable involved	n/a
1B (5:00)	New material	N/a
1B (5:00)	I feel like each week the new topic is the hardest for me to understand but then as time goes on I get it	n/a
1C (6:00)	N/a	N/a
1A (4:00)	Approaching the X problems	NA
1B (5:00)	the new way of dominating that was touched upon in class today	na
1A (4:00)	What we went over in today's lecture. (I was having problems with the zoom for the most part)	no :)
1A (4:00)	I might need some help with understanding last weeks homework question 2, I tried my best but gave up on part a after an hour and after almost crying in Powel over the homework	None
1B (5:00)		Notes on slides
1C (6:00)	Maybe 4C	Nothing
1A (4:00)	X problems	Work on x problems

Screenshot of Attendance Survey: In each of my section meetings, I have students fill out an attendance form which includes two questions: “What concepts in class are you most confused about?” and “Suggestions to improve section?” My teaching is adaptive, and I use the responses to these questions to determine how much time should be spent on review of tricky concepts vs. other in-class activities.



Screenshot of Shared Drive Contributions: I post all of my teaching materials (including lecture slides, example problems, and syllabi) to a shared Google Drive accessible to all the TAs in my department. Junior TAs can view the materials and use them to create their own.

"Josh Goetz is ADORED by his section. He explains class concepts clearly and eloquently; it is clear he understands the material and has a passion for the subject. He provides relevant practice problems during our discussion section. He answers student emails in a timely manner and responds to feedback on his section. He is almost always available for questions. In weeks 9 and 10, he even added extra hours to help students work through our problem sets, often staying 10-30 minutes longer than he had planned. At the same time, Josh maintains high standards for students and expects that work is completed in its entirety, on time, and with total academic honesty. As for critiques, I would only suggest Josh continue to use the Google Form he has been using for attendance and feedback. It was a great way to ensure student needs were met throughout the quarter, which shifted depending on the content (PSNEs, MSNEs, iterative elimination and predictions, voting agendas, etc.; sometimes a lecture recap was helpful, other times working through HW problems was the best use of time)."

"I found Josh to be a very attentive and caring TA. His commitment to the material, and students ability to understand was made evident at the start of the quarter. Communication was stellar. Following section we would receive a copy of the presentation, the problems worked on (if applicable), and the answers to these problem sets (if applicable). If there were adjustments to office hours, it was communicated using a reasonable amount of time in advance. Throughout section, he articulated and projected well. Having attended office hours, Josh was very caring and pursued assisting each student in a way which assured they understood the topic. Whenever multiple students were present, he made sure to answer the questions at hand, but not spend all his time with one person. There was always a follow up after assisting students if any ideas needed to be clarified. Thank you. It was easy to ask questions. I never felt lesser, or dumb when I could not immediately understand what was being reviewed in section or when asking for support. This was not only because Josh is kind, but because he was able to foster an environment within the classroom where students supported students. Throughout class, he would ask how we felt about what was being taught. Even if you were the only student who wanted him to go over something again, he reassured you that this material is hard and despite being the only person admitting you'd like a greater clarification, you are in no way the only one."

"I always loved to go to section to hear Joshua's stories about his travels before section officially started. He was very knowledgeable about the class and course materials, even including current events to talk about topics learned that week. He helped us prepare for the exam and especially the essay, using his humor to lighten the mood over darker subjects. He was very passionate about teaching and about Political Science, and he inspired me to look for careers outside my path to incorporate World Politics. WE LOVE JOSHUA!"

"Josh was seriously one of the best TAs I've had at UCLA; his sections were very engaging and informative, and he is super approachable. I had to miss a couple of sections this quarter due to some sickness/family emergencies, and he was always very understanding. He is an amazing addition to the political science department!"

“Josh was amazing. He was very good at explaining the course material in a way that was easy for us to understand and follow along with. He was also very accessible and ready to answer questions.”

“TA Josh was an excellent TA and was very knowledgeable on topics that were shown throughout the course. He offered tons of help and homework assistance and was welcoming to everyone who wanted to attend sections and needed help with any part of the assignments/homework.”

“This TA would ask us weekly what we wanted our discussion to focus on, which was very helpful when we needed more help on one thing one week and another the next. He explained class concepts extremely well, which made understanding things so much easier, which at times was necessary.”

“Did his best to teach students and help with anything we did not understand. Was very welcoming during office hours and very easy to reach if we needed to consult with him about anything. Truly knowledgeable about the topic and did a great job explaining the concepts in a way where everyone understood. One of the best TAs I’ve had!”

“I think that the TA was absolutely excellent. Whenever I got confused in class, more than likely I would get the clarification that I needed during the discussion. He was always well prepared and supported us in any way that he could.”

“The TA was genuinely one of the most helpful TAs I’ve ever had. He broke down concepts, difficult problems, and questions from students super well. I always felt comfortable when needing help.”

“Josh is one of the best TA's I have had at UCLA. This class has been extremely difficult for me to understand, and without Josh I would probably be failing. Josh uses our input on how we would like the time in discussion to be used. This is extremely helpful because of the difficulty of the class it makes it more manageable.”

“Josh was an amazing TA - he held multiple office hours to help students through the challenging Homework and X Problems etc. Literally the best TA I have ever had!!!!! Thank you so much Josh we all appreciate you!!!!”

“Joshua was a great teaching assistant. The content of this course was generally challenging to understand at times, but Joshua always tried his best to help students understand it. He provided numerous examples and tried different teaching methods to see which ones worked best. Overall, Joshua was an excellent teaching assistant, and he was always very understanding and accommodating to students and their situations.”

Groupwork Problem: On the next page I include a fun in-class groupwork problem from my Game Theory class. I wrote the problem to be similar to an upcoming exam problem in terms of the underlying logic, but dressed up in a creative scenario that students found entertaining.

PS 30 Groupwork Problem (Section 11/16/23)

Scenario: The residents of Freedom Valley are debating how much money to spend on a statue of the city's hometown hero, Tubaman. This has become a flashpoint of local politics and is predicted to be the only relevant issue in the upcoming mayoral election. The town is divided on the following lines:

- 40% of residents want to spend no money on the statue
- 30% of residents want to spend $1 million on the statue
- 12% of residents want to spend $2 million on the statue
- 4% of residents want to spend $3 million on the statue
- 14% of residents want to spend $4 million on the statue

There are two mayoral candidates: Julian and Meldahyde. Both candidates are seeking to adopt positions on the statue issue that appeal to the most voters. They may select $0, $1M, $2M, $3M, or $4M as their proposed cost of the statue. Voters will choose who to vote for based on whichever candidate is closer to their ideal position (e.g. if Julian chooses $4M and Meldahyde chooses $1M, a voter whose ideal position is $2M will vote for Meldahyde. If Julian chooses $3M and Meldehyde chooses $1M, the $2M voter will be indifferent, and decide their vote via coin flip*). Candidates decide their positions simultaneously.

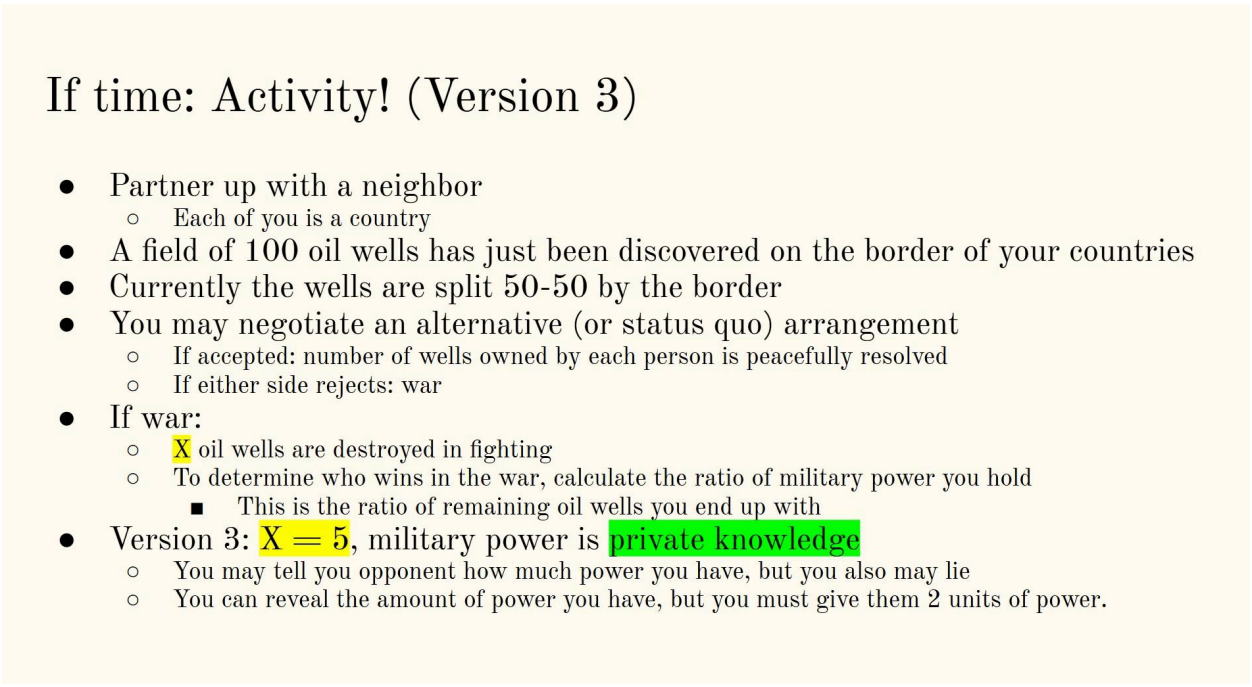
a) Please model this as a strategic form game and find the pure strategy Nash equilibrium.

b) In words, explain what this means. What positions will the candidates stake out? Who will be elected? And how much money will the town spend on the statue?

c) The current mayor, Sven, is a Tubaman fanatic, and would prefer to spend $7 million on the Tubaman statue. Sven is a novice game theorist, and is trying to figure out what strategy he should pursue to ensure that more money is spent on the statue. He is considering two strategies (detailed below). Which strategy will result in more money being spent on the statue?

   i) Sven attended Professor Chwe's lecture on Monday and understands that the addition of a third party candidate can sometimes alter the positions taken by other candidates. Thus, by entering the race as a third-party candidate, Sven might be able to shift the playing field and increase the price tag of the winning candidate's policy. **Sven's first option is to enter the race as a third-party candidate, promising to spend $7 million on the statue.**

   ii) The city's treasury has $1.5 million in crisis funds explicitly reserved for emergencies. Rather than entering the race, **Sven's second option is to simply drain the account to pay for the statue.**



Gamified Learning Activity: I include a picture of a slide describing an in-class activity I developed for my World Politics class. The game is meant to illustrate the “bargaining model of war”: an important but subtly complex topic in World Politics. I believed that students would learn better through friendly competition with one another, which would allow them to internalize the logic of wartime bargaining more easily than they would in a lecture.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

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Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Josh challenged me and the other students to work on problems ourselves, rather than give us the answers through slides at the beginning, to ensure that everyone was engaged and internalizing the lecture material. Especially in game theory lessons, creating and solving simultaneous games does not necessarily come easily. Josh allowed us to work through the problems in groups and share our reasoning behind certain decisions before showing us the solution. He also inspired me to become a more political science-oriented writer through his thoughtful paper feedback. I tend to write in a more narrative manner, but he encouraged me to be direct in my arguments and to fully flesh out all ideas when I left my thoughts unclear towards the end of paragraphs. Josh challenged me to build on existing academic work on the Russia-Ukraine conflict by providing questions in his feedback. Some encouraged me to add a counterargument, others found holes in my thoughts, but all of his comments strengthened my writing ability in an academic context.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One thing that Josh did that I thought was particularly beneficial for my, and other students', learning was the time he dedicated to providing feedback on our paper outline and rough draft well in-advance of the final due date. Having more incremental deadlines helped me stay on schedule for the large assignment, but also allowed me to adapt my ideas to new concepts we covered in the course. Josh provided his own feedback and comments after submission, but he also created a collaborative environment for students to peer review their work. My paper and outline was shared with around six students throughout the quarter who all gave their recommendations and insights during our discussion section. Hearing outside perspectives is extremely beneficial when writing an academic paper, especially one that covers such a relevant and complex topic. Josh provided guiding questions for paper review, which ensured that students addressed all aspects of the rubric and created strong and complete arguments. I received actionable feedback from many of my peers and from Josh, which I believe was essential in shaping my final paper.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES

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February 11, 2026

Dear Award Committee:

I am writing this letter to warmly recommend Joshua (Josh) Goetz for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Josh was the Teaching Assistant for my African Political Economy (POL SCI 151b) class in Winter 2024. This is a challenging class for students – in addition to challenging readings, it also requires students to apply basic game theoretic models to various questions relevant for Africa (state development, civil war, economic development, etc.), and to conduct independent research. Each student researched a specific African country over the course of the quarter, collecting information about their country relating to the readings of the week, and then wrote a final research paper (individually or in a small group) that focuses on one particularly topic. Josh's teaching in the weekly discussion sections was critical in helping students to learn the game theory models, the substantive material, and to work on the research assignments throughout the quarter. He also helped them identify a final paper research topic for their selected country and guided them in writing their research papers.

Josh and his fellow TA also took the initiative to go beyond what I ordinarily expect from TAs and wrote a more detailed final paper grading rubric to help the students understand what was required for a successful research paper.

Josh's successful teaching was demonstrated when one of his students, Kavin Ganesan, won first place in the 2024 UCLA Library Prize for Undergraduate Research in the First-Year Category for the paper he wrote for the class, *The Impact of Natural Resources on Civil Conflict in the Democratic Republic of the Congo.* Josh also took the time to attend the luncheon to celebrate the winners and spoke about Kavin at the ceremony.

I believe Josh's teaching was exemplary and deserving of the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you require any additional information about Josh at tyson.roberts@ucla.edu.

Sincerely,
Tyson Roberts, Ph.D.